

translating it into simple logical arguments would rob it of a varying degree of its potency, sometimes excessively; nothing can be more bland than translated poetry. A convincing argument of the role of language is the existence of surviving holy languages, uncorrupted by the no-nonsense tests of daily use. Semitic religions, that is Judaism, Islam, and original Christianity understood the point; keep a language away from the rationalization of daily use and avoid the corruption of the vernacular. Four decades ago, the Catholic church translated the services and liturgies from Latin to the local vernaculars; it can be argued that this caused a drop in religious beliefs. Suddenly religion subjected itself to being judged by intellectual and scientific, without the aesthetic, standards. The Greek Orthodox church made the lucky mistake, upon translating some of its prayers from Church-Greek into the Semitic-based vernacular spoken by the Grecosyrians of the Antioch region (Southern Turkey and Northern Syria), of choosing classical Arabic, an entirely dead language. My folks are thus lucky to pray in a mixture of dead *Koiné* (Church Greek) and no less dead Koranic Arabic.

What does this point have to do with a book on randomness? Our genes dictate a need for *péché mignon*. Even the economists, who usually find abstruse ways completely to escape reality, are starting to understand that what makes us tick is not necessarily the calculating accountant in us. We do not need to be rational and scientific when it comes to the details of our daily life – only in those that can harm us and threaten our survival. Modern life seems to invite us to do the exact opposite; become extremely realistic and intellectual when it comes to such matters as religion and personal behavior, yet as irrational as possible when it comes to markets and matters ruled by randomness. I have encountered colleagues, “rational” no-nonsense people, who do not understand why I cherish the poetry of Baudelaire or obscure (and often impenetrable) writers like Elias Canetti, Borges, or Saint-John Perse. Yet they get sucked into listening to the “analyses” of a television “guru”, or into buying the stock of a company they know absolutely nothing about, based on tips by neighbors who drive expensive cars. The Vienna Circle, in their dumping on Hegel-style verbiage-based philosophy, explained that, from a scientific standpoint, it was plain garbage, and, from an artistic point of view, it was inferior to music. I

have to say that I find Baudelaire far more pleasant to frequent than CNN newscasters or listening to George Will.

There is a Yiddish saying: *If I am going to be forced to eat pork, it better be of the best kind*. If I am going to be fooled by randomness, it better be of the beautiful (and harmless) kind. This point will be made again in Part III.